

According to the officials, the Shah government in Nepal has been positive about its engagement with New Delhi.

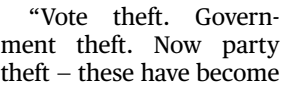
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Mr. Nishant did not react to his projection as future Chief Minister but rather chose to use the platform to attack the Opposition Rashtriya Janata Dal (RJD).

EC should restore party symbol to Mamata: Cong.

After defecting from the Congress, Ms. Banerjee set up the Trinamool Congress, with the symbol of grass and twin flowers, about 28 years ago, in 1998. She defeated the Left Front government in the 2011 Assembly polls and served as Chief Minister of the State for 15 years, before losing to the Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP) in the 2026 Assembly polls.

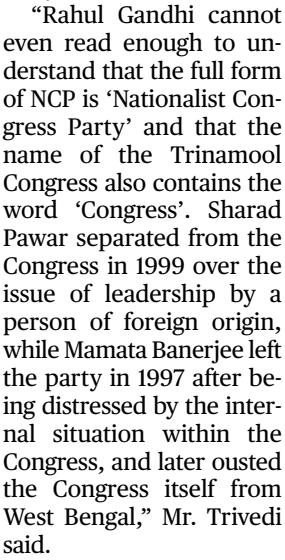


Congress general secretary (organisation) K.C. Ve-

Observing that whoever opposes the BJP is dealt a fatal blow and their entire electoral existence is snatched away from them, the Congress leader said that the EC has once again proven that it is nothing more than a puppet in the hands of the BJP – a tool to destroy democracy bit by bit.

Congress betrayed allies, sidelined veterans: BJP

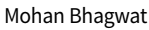
At a press conference, he said that “the Congress, throughout its history, has betrayed its allies, brought down elected State governments in an unconstitutional manner, and repeat-



He further alleged that senior Congress leader Ashok Gehlot was recently "prevented from becoming Congress president". "The betrayal of Chaudhary Charan Singh during the Janata Party regime, the merger of the Lok Dal in Haryana in 1980, and the absorption of Chimanbhai Patel's Janata Dal into the Congress in 1992" were among the alleged instances he cited.

Secularism is a 'modern' concept, does not fit India's tradition, says RSS chief

“Take the example of the sun. Even if you do not believe in the sun, it will still rise and set,” Mr. Bhagwat said while speaking at the ‘Yuva Dharma Sansad’ in Ujjain, Madhya Pradesh. He added that people should not live under the illusion that everything op-



Regarding the definition of secularism, the RSS chief termed it a modern concept that does not fit India's traditional under-

Sharing his understanding of the Western concept of secularism, the RSS chief said it emerged from a historical conflict between kings and religious authorities. “....there was a conflict between kings and religious authorities over

who should have power. After much bloodshed, a compromise was reached which was that the king would look after this world, and the religious authorities would look after the other world. So, secular came to mean the material or worldly sphere," he said adding that India's tradition seeks both material prosperity and freedom from anger, greed and jealousy, viewing life holistically through dharma. Hence "secular does not fit the Indian context", he said, claiming that "whenever India was governed by Indians, the country followed the path of dharma".

Congress disputes panel chairperson's claim on its MPs supporting UPI MDR

Congress MP Manish Tewari, a member of the committee, said the suggestion that Opposition members had endorsed the proposal by not recording a dissent was “un-

Responding to reports quoting Mr. Mahtab as saying that the presence of Opposition members and their participation in the panel's report were matters of record, Mr. Tewari said the committee's recommendation was only to "explore" a revenue model for sustaining the UPI ecosystem.

"The core of the com-

Mr. Tewari said the government's subsequent action-taken report, laid in the Lok Sabha on August 12, similarly stated that the Department of Financial Services was "currently exploring" two options – restoring MDR for certain

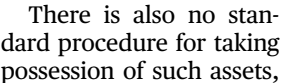
Congress general secretary in-charge of communications Jairam Ramesh, tagging Mr. Tewari's post, said Mr. Mahtab was "otherwise a seasoned and sober Parliamentarian but is 2024 Batch Odisha cadre of the BJP". "This explains his eagerness to mislead and misinform," he said on X.

Cong. targets PM over CBI probe against Arunachal CM

He said the Supreme Court, on August 24, had noted that instead of providing the relevant documents, the State government had supplied "huge chunks of documents" to the CBI. "It is extraordinary and totally unacceptable that the CM continues in office...." he said.

JPC members question Centre on FCRA Bill's asset takeover provisions

The Union Home Ministry, in its submission, said the proposed amendments are aimed at making the use of foreign contributions more transparent and accountable.

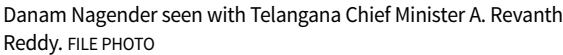


According to sources, several Opposition members, including the DMK's P. Wilson and the Trinamool Congress's Menaka Guruswamy, argued that

Citing this backdrop, the Home Ministry said the latest amendment is, at its core, a “national security” legislation.

Telangana HC disqualifies BRS MLA Danam Nagender who defected to Congress

On Friday, the High Court said Mr. Nagender “stands disqualified from April 23 of 2024 as member of Telangana Assembly” in terms of paragraph 2 (1) (a) of the Tenth Schedule and Article 191(2) of the Constitution, having contested as a candidate



Declines request

Allowing the writ petitions filed by the BRS and the BJP, seeking to quash the Speaker's earlier order, the Bench directed the authorities to communicate the verdict copy to the Speaker's secretary and the Election Commission. It declined the request of Mr. Nagender's counsel to

In a post on social media platforms, KTR wrote, “Satyameva Jayate!! BRS MLA Danam Nagender who defected to Congress got disqualified by the Hon’ble High Court today.”



No hard ceilings

A rise in minimum PF pension will protect the worse-off among the retired

The Union Cabinet’s approval to raise the wage ceiling for mandatory coverage under the Employees’ Provident Fund Organisation (EPFO) from ₹15,000 to ₹25,000, though belated, is commendable. The BJP-led government has finally responded to this long-standing demand of workers in the organised sector. Around 51 lakh additional employees may be brought under the PF fold, which has around 7.98 crore contributing members. Those in the wage slab of ₹15,000-₹25,000 will now be covered under the Employees’ Pension Scheme (EPS), 2026. Although Union Labour Minister Mansukh Mandaviya cited a government survey as the basis for the increase, the 12-year delay in implementing it should have been avoided. The Minister, who said that the average salary in private establishments was ₹23,000, should also make the survey’s findings public for a better understanding of the country’s overall wage situation. With some concerns having been raised that not every employer may be willing to make the additional contributions required after the revision, the government must ensure that all employers comply with the law.

So far, the government has been silent on revising the EPS minimum pension of ₹1,000, fixed in September 2014 alongside the previous revision in the PF wage ceiling. EPFO pensioners have been demanding the hike in the minimum pension amount. Before it assumed office at the Centre in 2014, the BJP had urged the Congress-led UPA government to keep the minimum pension at ₹3,000 and index it to inflation. Yet, it has not made even a symbolic beginning towards the indexation of pension to inflation. Moreover, about 45% of the nearly 82 lakh pensioners receive ₹1,000 or less. In March 2026, the Joint Parliamentary Standing Committee on Labour reminded the government that “the existing minimum pension amount is inadequate to meet even the basic needs of pensioners particularly in the ... scenario marked by ... rising healthcare and living expenses”. Also, little is known about the follow-up to the panel’s recommendation for “an urgent and comprehensive review of the minimum pension”. The EPFO must release the findings of actuarial assessment, made by valuers in recent years. This should also be beneficial to the PF body, as EPFO CEO Ramesh Krishnamurthi observed in an interview with *The Hindu* in August that “there is a misconception that the [pension] fund has unlimited resources”, while ruling out the reopening of the window for higher pensions. Even if the government is unwilling to restore the pre-2014 coverage, under which all employees were covered regardless of their wages, it should consider relaxation of the restriction on the coverage. Else, many pensioners will be pushed below the poverty line.

Continental glory

India might get another 100-medal haul from a smaller contingent

Even as Japan, known for efficiency, welcomes its third Asian Games and the first in 32 years, on Saturday, the Aichi-Nagoya Games have already earned the ‘worst ever’ tag because of accommodation and logistical issues. A country that successfully hosted two Olympics – in 1964, within two decades of suffering atomic bombings, and in 2021, behind closed doors amid the unprecedented COVID-19 pandemic – is now strangely struggling to accommodate more than 17,000 athletes and officials from 45 nations in hotels, containers and a cruise ship. Despite these issues, 501 of India’s athletes, including 267 men and 234 women, across 36 disciplines, will try to keep its flag flying high. At the previous Hangzhou Asiad, India had an impressive tally of 106 medals and was placed fourth behind China, Japan and South Korea. There is a significant drop in the number of Indian athletes, from 650-plus in 40 disciplines three years ago, following rationalisation, discouraging a mad rush because of the perks and money associated with the Asiad. Nevertheless, Indian sports authorities expect around 100 medals, which may noticeably improve the athlete-to-medal ratio.

The presence of 310 debutants in the contingent signals a brighter future for the country, which has spent nearly ₹800 crore on Asian Games preparations in the last cycle. Shooting and athletics, which together field 105 athletes, should continue to be the major contributors to India’s medals tally, followed by archery, boxing, badminton, squash and wrestling. Stars including Manu Bhaker, Mirabai Chanu, Lovlina Borgohain, P.V. Sindhu, Aman Sehrawat, Tajinderpal Singh Toor, Gulveer Singh, Harmanpreet Singh, Smriti Mandhana and Jasprit Bumrah will lead India’s campaign. At 39, squash player Joshna Chinnappa will be the first Indian to compete in seven consecutive Asian Games. The youngest athlete, 15-year-old cricketer Vaibhav Sooryavanshi, and the oldest, 55-year-old rider Shruti Vora, are the other attractions. Some attention will also be devoted to Indian men’s and women’s hockey teams, which will aim to win gold medals and secure berths at the 2028 Los Angeles Olympics. While India can take pride in fielding athletes in debut-making disciplines, such as mixed martial arts and teqball, it should ponder over its poor representation in swimming, gymnastics and cycling, which offer more medals and open avenues for Olympic glory. Meanwhile, the Indian men and women’s teams would be watched closely in cricket. In pushing for continental excellence, India should also remain vigilant about its deteriorating global reputation due to the sharply rising doping graph.

Technologies that once arrived in India through imports are increasingly being invented at home through local research institutions, industry, and startups. Three institutional foundations of an innovation economy are now advancing together: public research, corporate research and development (R&D), and deep-tech entrepreneurship. The transformation is yet incomplete, but the architecture is finally visible. Gallium Nitride (GaN) semiconductor technologies, critical for advanced radar, space systems, and next-generation communications, are increasingly being developed domestically, helping close a strategic gap in a tightly regulated, export-controlled field. At the same time, affordable immunotherapies developed in India are expanding access to advanced cancer care and demonstrating the country’s growing capacity for biomedical innovation.

Patent filings are often cited as a ready indicator of innovation. The filing numbers continue to show impressive growth. From just over 1,10,000 patent filings in 2024-25, the number grew to more than 1,43,000 in 2025-26, a 30.2% increase. Moreover, domestic applicants now account for almost seven in 10 filings.

However, the sheer volume of applications does not tell the complete story. Even a modest enquiry reveals an innovation story that begins to fray at the edges. The number of patents in force in India (just over 2,40,000 in 2025) is a fraction of those in China (5.7 million), the United States (3.5 million), and Japan (2.1 million); all these are 2024 data.

This suggests low grant rates, high abandonment rates, or a combination of both. Add to this meagre commercialisation, low R&D spending – India still spends just under 1% of GDP on research and development, against about 2.4% in China and 3.5% in the U.S. – and we see how far we are from a truly technology-driven, innovation-led economy.

The emerging pillars

However, there lies a resilient core, and shaping it are three strong and vital strands that promise to anchor India’s future. Public institutions with government support have made vital breakthroughs in long-gestation innovation. Private R&D spending exceeded that of all levels of government combined for the first time in 2024. This is expected to climb and account for 55% through 2025-26. Domestic industrial houses are beginning to reap rewards from focused and committed R&D. A maturing startup ecosystem is finding its feet beyond low-hanging service platforms, actively showcasing deep tech and complex manufacturing. That all three strands



Mukundan Chakrapani

Holds a PhD in science and a law degree and is an academic



Gaurav Jain

Founder of Hastin Research and an intellectual property rights expert helping enterprises, startups, and universities transform ideas into intellectual property

Homegrown research and deep-tech enterprise are helping India move beyond its identity as a services provider

are coming of age together bodes well for India.

In March 2023, Defence Research and Development Organisation (DRDO) scientists at the Solid State Physics Laboratory (SSPL) in Delhi and the Gallium Arsenide Enabling Technology Centre (GAETEC) in Hyderabad announced a breakthrough in making gallium nitride (GaN) monolithic microwave integrated circuits (MMICs). The technical know-how to make these circuits, which are critical for military and defence applications, was, by widely reported accounts, refused to India under the offset provisions of the Rafale fighter jet purchase from France. The DRDO is now actively transferring the technology for GaN High Electron Mobility Transistors (HEMTs)-based MMICs to be used in 5G/6G wireless infrastructure, electric vehicles on-board chargers, and renewable energy inverter systems. India is now one of seven countries to have mastered this technology, alongside China, France, Germany, Russia, South Korea and the U.S. AGNIT Semiconductors, a spin-off from the Centre for Nano Science and Engineering (CeNSE) at the Indian Institute of Science, Bengaluru is translating homegrown GaN technology to real-world commercial applications.

From implementer to innovator

While long-gestation R&D at public institutions is starting to pay off, there is growing optimism from academia and domestic industry-led R&D as well. The Bharat 6G Alliance (B6GA) is making rapid progress in its stated aim of contributing 10% of the global 6G patents by 2030. According to a review meeting by Union Minister for Communications Jyotiraditya Scindia, B6GA members have made more than 7,700 patent filings across 5G and 6G technologies, including over 4,400 foreign filings. But, these are applications, not yet grants or declared standard-essential patents, and their true impact remains to be seen. However, taken together with almost 3,000 technical contributions to 3GPP last year, a 15-fold increase from 2020, these figures point in the right direction. The World Intellectual Property Organization’s 2025 Patent Cooperation Treaty rankings showed that Jio Platforms Limited had broken into the top 20 international patent filers for the first time, rising more than 300 places to be placed 19th overall.

While patent numbers are only a part of the story, participation in standards bodies and intellectual property ownership increasingly determine who captures value from future communication networks. India is securing ownership of critical digital infrastructure and is moving from being a standard-implementer to a standard-setting innovator.

Deep-sea discovery, environmental responsibility

India is standing at the threshold of a new frontier. But the most important question is not how deep we can go, how much we can mine, or how much wealth lies beneath the ocean floor. It is more fundamental: Should everything that can be technologically exploited necessarily be exploited? The question is particularly important as India strengthens its position in deep-sea exploration and develops the scientific and technological capabilities to access one of the least understood parts of the planet.

A growing deep-sea footprint

India is not new to seabed mineral exploration and holds three International Seabed Authority (ISA) exploration contracts covering approximately 95,000 square kilometres across the Central Indian Ocean Basin, Central Indian Ridge and Carlsberg Ridge in the international seabed area. Its exploration has identified an estimated 366 million tonnes of polymetallic nodules containing nickel, copper, cobalt and manganese, alongside extensive environmental and biodiversity studies.

Under the Deep Ocean Mission, India is developing deep-sea mining technology, underwater robotics and the MATSYA-6000 human submersible, while the National Institute of Ocean Technology has tested a mining machine at depths of about 5,270 metres. At the same time, biodiversity surveys across 19 seamounts have studied around 1,300 deep-sea organisms, including nearly 23 species reported as new to science. These achievements also impose a profound responsibility to decide whether technological ability should ultimately lead to exploitation.

Technological progress can create a dangerous assumption: if we can exploit something, we should. But the deep ocean challenges this logic. It is a complex and poorly understood ecosystem, and India’s own biodiversity research continues to reveal previously unknown organisms. We cannot confidently predict the consequences of



P. Ragavan

Marine biologist with over a decade of professional experience in the conservation and management of coastal and marine environments

India has an opportunity to become a global leader not only in deep-sea technology but also in deep-sea ecological governance

large-scale seabed disturbance while our understanding of these ecosystems remains incomplete. This is not an argument against science, but for more science before potentially irreversible intervention. Deep-sea minerals may have legitimate strategic importance for India’s renewable-energy, electric-mobility and advanced-manufacturing ambitions. However, strategic importance cannot automatically become ecological permission. Before considering extraction, India should ask whether the minerals are genuinely necessary at the proposed scale, whether alternatives exist, and whether demand can be reduced through recycling, efficiency, substitution and a circular economy. Necessity must be demonstrated, not presumed.

India’s investment in deep-ocean science need not imply a commitment to commercial mining. Exploration can advance knowledge, biodiversity assessment, environmental baselines and technology without leading to exploitation. Mining, however, would physically disturb the seabed. Therefore, adaptive management alone cannot guarantee ecological protection. India has an opportunity to adopt a stronger principle before exploitation begins: the question should not be “How can we mine with minimum damage?” but “Do we need to mine at all?” Since India’s ISA activities remain at the exploration stage, this is the right time to establish a high ecological threshold for any future decision to exploit.

Science must also teach us to say ‘no’

The deep ocean is now emerging as the next frontier for economic growth. Yet, we expect the ocean to regulate climate and support biodiversity while extending industrial activity into its least understood ecosystems. The ocean should not become a place where the environmental costs of human consumption are simply relocated. Scientific progress should not mean making more of nature exploitable and

There is also a marked shift in India’s startup ecosystem. Buoyed by the government’s commitment to Research, Development, and Innovation (RDI) and private capital matched by initiatives such as the more than \$2.5 billion in deep-tech commitments made by members of the India Deep Tech Alliance (IDTA), Indian startups are aiming farther and higher than before. Pixxel Space, founded by two Birla Institute of Technology and Science (BITS) Pilani alumni, is carving a niche in hyperspectral imaging technology with six satellites in orbit and a full constellation of 18 to 24 planned. The Vikram-1 low earth orbit launch by Skyroot Aerospace and the IIT Madras nurtured Agnikul Cosmos’s parallel push towards fully reusable launch vehicles promise to strengthen India’s role as a frugal space technology leader.

Startups such as ImmunoACT, incubated at IIT Bombay in partnership with the Tata Memorial Centre, are expanding access to advanced and affordable health care. NexCAR19, India’s first indigenous CART cell therapy, has delivered effective cancer treatment at a tenth of typical treatment costs. Leveraging the Biotechnology Industry Research Assistance Council (BIRAC) early-stage support, Bengaluru-based Remidio Innovative Solutions is at the forefront in the fight against preventable blindness, such as diabetic retinopathy and glaucoma, through smartphone enabled retinal imaging systems and AI.

The direction is clear

These examples do not by themselves make India an innovation superpower but demonstrate that the three strands are coming together to weave an enduring innovation ecosystem. The GaN story illustrates the emerging innovation pipeline. Government laboratories developed the foundational capability, academic institutions nurtured the talent and research ecosystem, and startups such as AGNIT are now carrying the technology into commercial markets.

However, sustaining these three strands will demand more work, from standardising tech-transfer terms for publicly funded IP and expanding examiner capacity at the patent office, to funding the translational gap between a granted patent and a first paying customer. Yet, as we look through the innovation lens, the direction is clear. India is gradually shedding its identity as a back-office service provider and strengthening the institutions that enable nations to generate their own technology, intellectual property, and industrial capabilities. The journey remains unfinished, but the contours of an innovation economy are beginning to form.

The views expressed are personal

LETTERS TO THE EDITOR

Tariff threats, diplomacy

While maintaining a robust bilateral relationship with the United States is strategically vital, foreign policy cannot be dictated by the threat of economic coercion (Page 1, “U.S. clears Russia sanctions Bill; India faces tariff threat”, September 18). True partnerships are built on mutual respect and an understanding of each other’s domestic

compulsions. Imposing 100% tariffs would not only strain India-U.S. ties but could also destabilise international energy markets, leading to wider global economic friction. India must continue its balanced diplomatic approach — diversifying its energy sources while keeping communication channels open with Washington to resolve trade frictions through dialogue

rather than compliance.
Nagarajamani M.V.,
Hyderabad

Tata’s crisis of governance

Despite the leading roles played by the Tata Group in India’s growth in semiconductors, defence, software and electronics, the recent governance crisis and boardroom divisions at Tata Sons over leadership tenure and regulatory pressures pose a systemic

risk to the broader economy. The possible legal deadlock involving the Tata Trusts and regulatory mandates could stall vital national projects, highlighting the urgent need for an amicable resolution rather than protracted feuds. This is essential both in the national interest and to uphold the reputation of the Tata name, which is held in high esteem by the

people of India.
Rajakumar Arulanandham,
Palayamkottai, Tamil Nadu

There is something quietly damning about a company that discovers the value of “leadership continuity” only when it needs to appear stable to outsiders. What this exposes is how thin the group’s commitment to its own governance standards becomes when a market debut is at stake. An

‘outgoing’ chairman’s stated principle was treated as a formality to be abandoned whenever it no longer suited investor optics. That is not stewardship. It is a company discovering, rather conveniently, that its rules mattered only until they became inconvenient.

Yashvi Patel,
Anand, Gujarat

Letters emailed to letters@thehindu.co.in must carry the postal address.

GROUND ZERO



The private farmhouse on the outskirts of C.K. Tandya village that was allegedly being used as a counterfeit drug repackaging and re-labelling facility. MURALI KUMAR K.

A dangerous dose of deception

A heap of discarded medical waste near a farmhouse in South Bengaluru district led police to an alleged counterfeit drug repackaging unit and to an inter-State network supplying medicines to hospitals and clinics. The counterfeit drugs allegedly reached patients who were being treated for serious illnesses, including cancer.

Shilpa Elizabeth and Imran Gowhar report on the questions raised on accountability and patient safety

In mid-August, along the Bengaluru-Mysuru expressway, an agricultural labourer in C.K. Tandya village in South Bengaluru district (formerly known as Ramanagara) noticed something unusual on a strip of farmland: a heap of medical waste.

This wasn't the first time that the villagers in South Bengaluru had noticed suspicious objects or activity around the area which contained a farmhouse, say the police. They had seen men frequently moving in and out of it on a scooter without a number plate. They had also seen courier and e-commerce delivery vehicles making regular trips to the secluded location.

Spanning nearly eight acres and fenced by a compound wall, the farmland is situated on the outskirts of the village. According to the police, the owners, who live in Bengaluru, seldom visited the place.

The villagers would whisper among themselves about what they suspected – until the day the labourer decided to report the dumped medical waste to the local beat police.

The officers at Taverekere police station put the farmhouse and the movements around it under surveillance, while also making inquiries about the property and its occupants. The people they spoke to did not seem to know anything substantial.

According to an officer, the police learned that the farmhouse had been rented about a year earlier. But what was happening inside the compound remained unclear.

Days later, the police and Karnataka's health department, in a joint operation, decided to enter the premises. What they saw there – labels, medicine boxes, drugs, and other items associated with the preparation and packaging of medicines – changed the nature of the investigation. They alerted senior officers, who joined hands with officers from the State Drugs Control Department and conducted a raid on August 18.

The police took four people into custody. They discovered that the secluded farmhouse was being used as a counterfeit drug repackaging and re-labelling facility. What began as a local's suspicion had opened the door to a much larger pharmaceutical investigation.

According to investigators, the operation involved the procurement of low-cost, substandard, or expired pharmaceutical formulations from other States, which were then transferred into fresh vials and given counterfeit labels and packaging. "The aim was to make the medicines appear as genuine products of established pharmaceutical companies and introduce them into the pharmaceutical supply chain," says a police official familiar with the investigation.

During the seizure, the police recovered more than 5,600 vials of counterfeit antibiotic injections used in treating serious bacterial infections. The total seizure was estimated at ₹4.91 crore.

They also seized ledgers, invoices, mobile phones, and other records, which provided them with details of the supply chain.

From a farmhouse to the big city

The police then moved their investigation beyond C.K. Tandya. A Special Investigation Team (SIT) was constituted.

The trail led to Bengaluru and to Krupa Healthcare, a wholesale pharmaceutical distributor located on a busy commercial street in the ci-



After my mother passed away, I started suspecting something, perhaps a nexus, but I was in no state of mind to think about it. Now I'm questioning everything.

MAHESHPRASAD UPADHYA

ty. According to the police, the operators in the farmhouse supplied medicines to Krupa Healthcare, which distributed them.

The police found that the counterfeit medicines were not limited to antibiotics, but also included critical-care injections and cancer medicines. They say some of the medicines were offered to hospitals at "discounts of up to 50%".

Krupa Healthcare owner Veeresh Kumar Jain, who was arrested by the SIT, allegedly employed more than 15 medical representatives to promote the medicines and offered commissions to push the discounted stocks to private hospitals and medical centres.

The police then found that the alleged racket was not confined to Karnataka. A joint force subsequently carried out simultaneous searches across Karnataka, Himachal Pradesh, Haryana, Tamil Nadu, Maharashtra, and Telangana. The police are currently on the hunt for Bengaluru resident R. Prashant, who they believe is a key figure in the network. He is currently in Azerbaijan, and is Jain's partner, say the police.

Unanswered questions

The families of patients are shocked and angry at these revelations. On his WhatsApp profile picture, Maheshprasad Upadhyia, 30, poses with his mother. A cervical cancer patient, she passed away in 2024. After hearing the news, Upadhyia, a native of Odisha, cannot help second-guessing the events before his mother's death.

She was diagnosed with cancer in 2022, he says. For a year, she underwent chemotherapy and radiotherapy in Mumbai. The doctors then suggested immunotherapy. As treatment in Mumbai was expensive and there were also logistical difficulties in travelling to the city, the family decided to shift treatment to Bhubaneswar.

"The doctor we consulted referred a Bengaluru-based pharmaceutical distributor to us. I bought a medicine from them. It cost ₹1,65,990 per vial. My mother needed two vials. The distributor said if we purchase one, we would get another free," recalls Upadhyia.

He searched online and found that the manufacturer did offer such a programme. He decided to go ahead with it.

Upadhyia spent about ₹20 lakh on the overall treatment. "But we saw no improvement in her condition," he says. "When she was diagnosed with cancer, the doctor had said she would live up to five years. My mother passed away in one and a half years."

Upadhyia sounds calm, but he admits within him a tumult of emotions – anger, suspicion, and



The raid at the farmhouse in C.K. Tandya village. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

helplessness. "One person who had got his father treated at the Bhubaneswar hospital had advised us against buying this medicine from this particular distributor," he says. "But we didn't listen since the doctor himself had advised it. After my mother passed away, I started suspecting something, perhaps a nexus, but I was in no state of mind to think about it. Now I'm questioning everything."

He confesses that there are times when he considers migrating abroad "after seeing how the corrupt try to profit from the desperation of the most vulnerable."

Parth Sharma, a resident of Gurugram, returned to India in 2017 to care for his ageing parents and mother-in-law, after spending 37 years abroad. "The people I came here for are no more," he says.

In October 2020, Sharma's mother was diagnosed with myelodysplastic syndrome, a condition where the bone marrow doesn't make enough healthy blood cells. The doctors informed the family that the disease was not curable. Given the patient's age – she was in her 70s – a bone marrow transplant was also not an option, they said. Nevertheless, treatment, including chemotherapy injections and blood transfusions, was started at a private hospital in December.

Sharma remembers that some of the expensive medicines were not available in India. "The doctor gave us the phone number of a person and said he would help get it imported. When you are desperate, you simply trust everyone. So, we contacted him," he says.

Sharma's mother's condition never improved. With her body too weak to fight the disease, she passed away in May 2021.

"After the report on the counterfeit drug racket came out, I started wondering more deeply about something I had suspected all along: were the medicines even working? We had spent a lot of money and given her the prescribed medicines. At that point, we trusted the system and did not even suspect the possibility of fake medicines," he says. He still has some of the tablets, which cost him around ₹80,000.

Living in uncertainty

The police say the suspect medicines have so far reached more than 90 hospitals and clinics in Karnataka and other States. While the State government has published a list of antibiotics seized during the Bidadi raid, it has not yet disclosed the names of oncology drugs or the hospitals and clinics that may have received the medicines, or the names and batch numbers of counterfeit medicines reportedly linked to serious illnesses such as cancer. There is pressure on the government to disclose this information.

According to the Karnataka Minister for Health and Family Welfare, U.T. Khader, the full list of spurious and counterfeit drugs has been communicated to the Union government and all State governments. "The SIT has taken charge of the investigation now. Once the report is finalised, we will reveal everything. We have got the list of hospitals. But when the SIT is there, it is not right on my part to disclose anything," he says.

As the SIT continues with its investigation, Upadhyia wonders what patients must be going through with the information they have. "Imagine their state of mind. Would they want to continue or discontinue treatment when they have no way of knowing whether the medicine they are taking is genuine or counterfeit," he asks.

Dr. B.S. Ajaikumar, radiation and medical oncologist and Founder and Chairman at Health-Care Global (HCG) Enterprises, says counterfeit drugs are a major problem in India today.

"I have been sounding the alarm on this for several years," he says. "Whenever somebody – say an insurance company – wants to bring drugs from outside, I don't allow it at HCG because I'm concerned it could be spurious. Any drug we purchase should come directly from the manufacturer. The authorities should also lay down stringent guidelines and ensure they are enforced. They should consult major users of oncology drugs like us, collaborate with us to develop a plan, and ensure spurious drugs don't enter the system."

Noting that cancer treatment often depends on the right drug, at the right dose, given at the

right time, Dr. Nitish Ranjan Acharya, Surgical Oncologist at Manipal Hospital, Bhubaneswar, points out that any compromise in the authenticity or quality of a medicine can directly affect a patient's treatment.

"If a patient receives a counterfeit, substandard, or expired medicine, the drug may not work as intended. This can delay disease control, allow the cancer to progress and, in some cases, affect the chances of achieving a good treatment response. The impact may be particularly difficult to identify because a lack of response can sometimes be mistaken for the cancer becoming resistant to treatment," he explains.

Dr. Acharya adds that there are more risks when the contents of the counterfeit drugs are unknown. "A drug could contain an incorrect dose, inactive ingredients, contaminants, or substances that may cause unexpected side effects. These risks can be especially serious for patients already receiving multiple cancer medicines," he notes. He also stresses the importance of appropriate storage and handling to maintain quality.

The question of accountability

The alleged racket also raises questions about what hospitals should do when patients may have already been exposed to counterfeit medicines. As S.V. Joga Rao, a lawyer who specialises in healthcare law and ethics, says, "Given the circumstances in India, a detailed investigation may take time. By that time, the spurious drugs may have found their way to patients."

According to him, hospitals need to work with investigating agencies to identify the medicines in question and their batch numbers. "If there is some kind of leeway in terms of information, the hospital has an ethical duty to inform potentially affected patients," he says.

Noting that regulatory authorities need to be mindful of Section 17B of the Drugs and Cosmetics Act, 1940, which defines a spurious drug, and Section 18, which prohibits their manufacture, sale, stocking, distribution and other related activities, Rao also points to the legal duty of hospitals to procure responsibly, verify authenticity, and detect sophisticated counterfeiting. "If there are warning signs, they need to respond to that. The duties of the hospitals and regulators operate concurrently, although they are different in nature. It is a shared responsibility," he says.

Dr. Gopal Dabade, president of Drug Action Forum, Karnataka, says, "Drug inspectors are the first line of foot soldiers, but they are not adequately equipped. Punishment for wrongdoing is also not stringent enough." He is a part of the All India Drug Action Network, a group of non-profits working to "increase access and improve the rational use of essential medicines".

Another reality is the high cost of medicines, particularly cancer drugs, which can create a parallel market for cheaper counterfeit versions. "Better access to good quality and affordable treatment is the crux of the issue," Dabade says.

Sylvia Karpagam, a public health doctor and researcher, says people must demand an accountable public health system as part of the election mandate. She also points to the responsibility of doctors, and questions the role they play in ensuring accountability within the healthcare system. "Doctors who harp about 'evidence-based practice' in allopathy go mum when such incidents occur. Other than for their own pay cheques and to oppose any form of regulation, one barely sees doctors protesting on behalf of patients," she says.

She also stresses the importance of adequate budgets, trained and sufficient staff, and regular public scrutiny. "Unless the government has an ongoing system to prevent drug rackets, and makes it known to the public through ongoing reports, these kinds of incidents will continue – some get picked up, and many don't."

SIT head C. Vamshikrishna says he cannot comment on the case while the investigation is on. Repeated phone calls and messages to reach Srinivas K. Commissioner of the Food Safety and Drug Administration, Karnataka, have not elicited any response.

elizabeth.shilpa@thehindu.co.in;
imran.gowhar@thehindu.co.in

KARNATAKA



Scenic: A homestay in Kodagu near Talacauvery. According to the Tourism Department, there are around 4,000 registered homestays in Karnataka. They are mostly concentrated in Kodagu, Chikkamagaluru, Hassan, Shivamogga, and Hampi. K. MURALI KUMAR

As homestays mushroom across Karnataka's tourist destinations, safety concerns and unauthorised establishments are putting the sector under scrutiny. The Tourism Department is now moving to streamline registrations, tighten regulations, and bring a new Bed & Breakfast policy, writes **Rashmi Patil**

A home away from home. That is the promise of homestays for tourists travelling from other countries, States, and cities to major tourist destinations in Karnataka. Local families in these accommodations offer tourists a warm and homely atmosphere even as they introduce them to a new culture and guide them to places to visit.

Such accommodations have caught the fancy of tourists in recent years, and according to the Tourism Department officials, there are around 4,000 homestays registered in Karnataka. They are mostly concentrated in Kodagu, Chikkamagaluru, Hassan, Shivamogga in south Karnataka, and Hampi in Vijayanagara district in north Karnataka. These districts attract majority of tourists during monsoon, weekends, and holidays.

However, some untoward incidents in recent times have raised questions about the enforcement of regulations. Most recently, in June 2026, during the hearing of an alleged rape case in a Kodagu homestay, the High Court of Karnataka urged the State government and the Tourism Department to frame comprehensive, multisector policies to address safety, compliance, and consumer protection concerns in the hospitality industry.



Tourists at the Virupaksha temple in Hampi. At the world heritage site too, homestays have mushroomed.

As per rules, it is mandatory for homestays across the State to register through the online portal of the Tourism Department or the Seva Sindhu Portal under the revised Karnataka Homestay Registration Guidelines, 2025.

Speaking to *The Hindu*, a senior official from the Tourism Department said that homestays have existed in Karnataka for decades and guidelines were put in place way back in 2006-07. “Since then, the registration of homestays is mandatory. From the past two years, the process has shifted to online portal. However, after some incidents came to light and keeping safety of tourists in mind, we implemented it strictly from June 2026. The department has instructed all Deputy Commissioners, in places where homestays come up, to implement the guidelines without fail.”

Despite the guidelines by the department, thousands of unauthorised homestays or Bed & Breakfasts (B&Bs) have come up across tourist destinations in the State. Neither the homestay associations nor the department has an estimate of them, but they agree that such businesses exist.

The Tourism Department official said: “There are only 4,000 authorised or registered homestays. While we don’t have an exact figure of unauthorised homestay, tourists must avoid going to such places.”

Meanwhile, Monthi Ganesh, president, Kodagu Homestay Owners’ Association, said: “At least 2,000 homestays in Kodagu are unauthorised, which means they operate without licence.” She said that people from other States take property on lease and start homestay businesses without following guidelines and procuring licence. “We have complained several times to the police and

Homestay registration is a must to earn people's trust. When incidents are reported, the owner can be held responsible

H.L. GIRIDHAR
President of Chikkamagaluru Homestay Owners' Association

the district administration, but it hasn’t yielded results.”

The association also goes on inspection of homestays when owners apply for a licence from the department, along with officials. At present, there are more than 2,000 homestays in Kodagu that are registered, and around 1,800 of them are affiliated with the association. “The issue of unauthorised homestays came to our notice when we started receiving complaints from tourists of brokers and agents taking them to faraway places for as low as ₹1,000 per person per day.”

The association brought it to the notice of the District Tourism Committee headed by the Deputy Commissioner of Kodagu and other industry veterans during a meeting held on September 11, 2026.

Monthi Ganesh said that every incident of a tourist being cheated, harassed, or ill-treated affects the industry. “Tourists start fearing coming to Kodagu and footfall drops. Authorised homestays are the way forward to tackle these issues.”

Somashekar S.J., Deputy Commissioner, Kodagu, said: “We are aware of unauthorised homestays. The district administration in collaboration with hospitality industry veterans will print a booklet for tourists with a list of authorised homestays, contact numbers, and addresses. Guidelines and emergency helpline numbers will be provided in case of issues during their journey and stay.”

The scenario in Chikkamagaluru is no different. H.L. Giridhar, president of Chikkamagaluru Homestay Owners’ Association, said while around 600 are registered, which includes both homestays and B&B category accommodations, there are over a thousand that are unauthorised and open only on the weekends when the demand from tourists for rooms is high. “The reason behind making registration mandatory is to earn people’s trust and see that when any incidents are reported, the homestay owner is held responsible.”

More transparency needed

Giridhar underlined the need for a transparent process to make this possible. “When I applied for a licence a few years ago, it took three months for the entire process. Another issue is lack of uniformity in the fees charged by the departments for various processes. For instance, panchayats can charge upto ₹500 for issuing NOC though



Tourists enjoying the view from Nandi Hills.

there is no such guideline. However, there are panchayats that charge ₹5,000 to ₹10,000 for issuing NOC (No Objection Certificate), which is not fair. The process of applying and getting a licence should be made easier for owners for the ease of doing business.”

He urged that the government should not encourage proliferation of B&Bs. “It will lead to homestays losing their USP of providing hospitality to guests in the presence of owner on the property. Let the government encourage more owners to run homestays in their own tourist destinations. If you commercialise the idea by allowing non-residents to enter the business, there will be competition forcing homestay owners to charge more in comparison to the existing prices,” he said.

In world heritage site Hampi too, homestays have mushroomed. In August 2026, Justice B. Veerappa, Upalokayukta, visited Hampi and directed officials to clear all unauthorised homestays located within the buffer zone and peripheral zone of historical monuments and sites.

According to the Upalokayukta, around 250 homestays were flagged as unauthorised. He asked the Deputy Commissioner of Koppal to take legal action against such homestays, disconnect power and water supply services, and submit a detailed report to the Upalokayukta. In his report, he highlighted how agricultural land was also used to build homestays and operate illegally. In response to this, Deputy Commissioner of Koppal district Suresh B. Itnal said the authorities have stopped providing electricity, water, and other facilities to unauthorised homestays. More than 200 such homestays have shut down, he said.

Siraj, homestay owner in Anegundi adjoining Hampi, said: “In 2025, when registration was made mandatory, I tried applying online. The website was not working for almost a year. Finally, in early 2026, I got my homestay registered. Now, one of my friends who runs a homestay has applied for registration, but it has been pending since four months.”

The Tourism Department official noted that the department has received over 1,000 applications from homestay owners in the past three to four months, but verification and issuing of licences are pending.

The official explained that homestays need to procure an NOC from gram panchayats, the Revenue Department and a clearance from the Police Department. “These three departments need to have access to one website and work in coordination whenever they go for an inspection. At present, the file moves from one department to the other manually, leading to delays in verification as the department officials are occupied with other daily issues. On the other hand, the gram panchayats have not streamlined this process online. The NOC by panchayats is given manually to owners, which is presented to the police by owners themselves. With such gaps, the process of verifying and issuing licences to homestays gets delayed,” he said.

Sakala website

To address this, the Department of Tourism is planning to bring all three departments on the existing Sakala platform.

The official said: “Whenever a homestay owner applies for a licence, the three departments must be able to upload necessary clarifications, NOC, or even objections. Finally, a district-level officer from the Tourism Department will inspect the homestay. If there are no violations, then the

Deputy Commissioner will issue the licence.”

While homestays are under the purview of non-commercial establishments, B&B category accommodations are under the purview of commercial establishments, but the nodal agency to regulate them is the Tourism Department. Recently, Tourism and Energy Minister K.J. George announced that the Karnataka government would introduce stringent regulations and separate frameworks for B&B establishments.

According to the Homestay Registration Guidelines, 2025, B&B category is a privately owned place, including buildings in farms and plantations where the owner of the establishment does not reside but an agent or an operator designated by them resides on the building premises for providing necessary services to visitors.

An official explained that the distinct frameworks for B&B are aimed at preserving the identity of genuine homestays so that it doesn’t hamper the tourism ecosystem, local economy, and business of owners running these homestays. B&B accommodations are at present registered as homestays because they function at homes with multiple rooms.

“Since B&B falls under the category of commercial establishments, they need to apply for land conversion from residence to commercial category, and agriculture to non-agriculture if it is a cultivation land. We are trying to integrate this land conversion process on the Bhoomi portal under the Revenue Department.”

At present, the department is working on various factors to streamline property tax to be levied on B&B properties, which is likely to be same as other commercial properties. The Es-coms concerned will verify the electricity meter and the tariff charges will be same as it is for commercial categories. The same goes for water tariff too, the official noted, adding that a single-window system will be introduced to simplify the process. Tourism, Police, Revenue departments, besides gram panchayats and district administrations will come under one umbrella.

A win-win situation

Elaborating the reasons behind government encouraging homestays and B&Bs, the official said that while Karnataka’s tourism destinations attract lakhs of tourists, it is not sustainable to go on building accommodations everywhere. “The government has been encouraging homestays and B&Bs so that it is a win-win situation for local people, tourists, and the government, while preserving the authenticity of the place. It is a sustainable way of promoting tourism. Money that the homestays charge is nominal when compared to resorts or hotels.”

The senior official said that once the single-window system for registration is put in place, the department will compile a comprehensive list of registered places, and link them with Google Maps and booking websites. “Whenever tourists check out the places, it must indicate the registration and take them to the genuine list of homestays under our department.” The department has plans to sync this data with the Police Department as well as respective district authorities.

Ajit Das, who loves to explore places during weekends, said: “When I look to book homestays, many private websites show addresses, but there is no guarantee if they are licensed. If the Tourism Department launches a website where it has a list of authorised homestays, it will ease the process of booking for tourists. It will also greatly help solo women travellers.”



Prime Minister Narendra Modi with BJP national president Nitin Nabin and the party's newly appointed national office-bearers during an organisational meeting at the BJP headquarters, in New Delhi on August 22. ANI

A piecemeal reset

Apart from the usual distribution of organisational berths to poll-going States, caste groups, and other demographics of sex and age, the new BJP team reflects the party's attempts at a reset. **Nistula Hebbar** reports on how three terms in power have brought both the pieties of the past and anxieties of the future into focus

Prime Minister Narendra Modi walked into a meeting of the newly appointed Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP) national office-bearers on August 22. The 64 office-bearers present assumed he would address them on how they should approach their assignments. Instead, he spent the next four-and-a-quarter hours individually querying them on their past organisational work.

The exchange was unhurried, with Modi at one point telling the audience that he too was once like them, a national office-bearer of the party during the late Atal Bihari Vajpayee's tenure as Prime Minister (1999-2004), say some of the new office-bearers.

The identification was interpreted in some quarters as a pep talk to the new team of how far organisational service can take you in the BJP, but for others it pointed to a unifying characteristic in a list of names that otherwise lacked a meta narrative, and instead, in a piecemeal fashion exhibited the political anxieties of the BJP.

This privileging of organisational experience by the Prime Minister was the highlight of the new team. The BJP, now in its third term in power and seeking a fourth in 2029, is, with this new team, attempting a reset amid various political anxieties.

Journalist Shekhar Iyer, who has tracked the BJP for decades, says, "The new team marks a big shift in the party top brass' approach to the challenges ahead of the 2029 Lok Sabha poll. Increasingly, the BJP is signalling to itself that, henceforth, the chosen men and women will represent less of their individual personality and more of their abilities and capabilities for the tasks to be accomplished."

This means the BJP is choosing workers over personalities, some of whom may not be known to the world outside the party. "If they meet the expectations of the top brass, they will move up the ladder faster," Iyer says.

The only exception to this weight given to backroom operators is former Union Minister and current general secretary Smriti Irani, whose oratorical skills have been considered valuable.

The only two general secretaries retained from the older team, Vinod Tawde and Sunil Bansal, have had a good run with Bihar and West Bengal respectively, States they were in charge of. Others such as general secretaries Satish Poonia and Biplab Deb, as well as new vice-president Ram Madhav also have a proven track record of behind-the-scenes organisational work in Jammu and Kashmir, West Bengal and Haryana.

The BJP's anxieties have more to do with the party's ability to run the election machinery.

2024 Lok Sabha poll and its discontents

The new list of office-bearers hides within it attempts to settle the disquiet engendered by the results of the Lok Sabha poll of 2024, which saw the BJP lose its single-party majority.

The unease between the BJP and its ideological mothership, the Rashtriya Swayamsevak Sangh (RSS), stood out during the 2024 election. It became public when the then BJP president, J.P. Nadda, said during an interview that the party did not require the help of the RSS as electoral muscle, adding that the BJP was "saksham" or



The BJP is signalling to itself that, henceforth, the chosen men and women will represent less of their individual personality and more of their abilities and capabilities for the tasks to be accomplished

SHEKHAR IYER
Journalist

adequate for the task.

Long-held resentments within the RSS – of the parent organisation being overlooked while its political wing, the BJP, flexed its muscles – burst to the fore, with particularly harmful effects for the party's prospects in Maharashtra, where the Mahayuti alliance of the BJP, the Eknath Shinde-led Shiv Sena and the Ajit Pawar-led Nationalist Congress Party suffered electoral losses.

In the Assembly election in the State later that year, this uneasiness was resolved by a coordination mechanism between the BJP and the RSS. The latter was headed by office-bearer Atul Limaye, who helped deliver a win to the alliance.

The awareness that the RSS and the BJP needed each other to remain in power had been reinforced by the results of the Lok Sabha election of 2024.

The return of Madhav, first as poll in charge of Jammu and Kashmir in the 2024 Assembly election, the first such poll after it became a Union Territory and after the reading down of Article 370 in 2019, and as vice-president in August 2026 was the second part of this rapprochement.

The understanding within the Sangh Parivar that internal issues should not endanger the government was driven home to the RSS and the BJP. Madhav, in an interview to *The Hindu*, described himself as someone who believed in a "middle path". In this case, he was the halfway meeting point for the BJP and RSS.

Insider, outsider

A few months before the BJP announced its new team of national office-bearers, a meeting was held at Defence Minister and former party president Rajnath Singh's residence.

Those present included not just the new BJP president Nitin Nabin, but also Union Home Minister Amit Shah, party's general secretary (organisation) B.L. Santhosh, and senior office-bearers of the RSS.

The topic of discussion was how to reconcile the aspirations of old-timers in the party with the flood of newcomers in the BJP since it came to power. This was not a new discussion. In an interview just before the Assembly poll in Assam this year, BJP vice-president and Assam in-charge Bajajant Panda, who was earlier with the Biju Janata Dal, told *The Hindu* that selectivity in distributing tickets to newcomers was the answer to the conundrum.

The BJP has profited from outside talent, especially since 2014. Three of the party's Chief Ministers – Himanta Biswa Sarma in Assam, Samrat Choudhary in Bihar and Suwendu Adhikari in West Bengal – have joined the BJP from other political parties.

In the new team, Rohan Gupta, who joined the BJP from the Congress, and Sandeep Pathak, who came from the Aam Aadmi Party (AAP), have been appointed as national secretaries. They don't qualify as long-term players within the party, but they do bring in the value of being backroom operators, with Pathak especially valued for his organisational work for AAP before the Punjab poll of 2022, which AAP had won.

The apprehensions of old-timers in the BJP, who see the party expanding with little reward for themselves, are being soothed by making newcomers do the organisational grind.

All the president's men

Another issue that arose during the Lok Sabha poll of 2024 was the perception that the organisation's work was subordinate to that of the government, that the strings of the party were being pulled by a high command, at the cost of the authority of the BJP president.

"Naddaji had been a general secretary in the national team in the past, served an apprenticeship under Amit Shah as the national working president of the BJP in 2019 and his subsequent team gave no inkling of his own personal likes or

dislikes," said a senior office-bearer in the BJP.

In Nabin's case, however, he has had remarkable autonomy in bringing people with whom he shares a good rapport into his team. BJP's national secretaries Swadesh Singh and Siddharth Shambhu are known to enjoy Nabin's trust, as does the newly appointed chief of the party's Scheduled Caste wing, Shivesh Ram. The new social media cell chief of the party, Deepak Mhaskey from Chhattisgarh, has also been hand-picked by Nabin, who had worked with him when Nabin handled the 2023 Assembly poll in that State.

Gen Z protests and social media

It was Mhaskey's appointment, replacing long-serving IT cell chief Amit Malviya, that made headlines after the new team was announced. The announcement came on the back of the Gen Z protests against the NEET paper leak, and the pasting that the BJP and the government took on social media throughout that period. That was a departure for a party that had, for the previous 12 years held a tight hold over the narrative, especially on social media.

One reason given for his replacement was the need for the BJP to strategise differently to counter this narrative. At a brainstorming session held soon after the new team's announcement, with many of its young leaders called in, it was decided not to look at Gen Z as a homogeneous unit. Ami Shah, a political communications professional and visiting faculty member at IIM Bangalore, says that the BJP had hyperlocalised communications in Maharashtra in 2014.

She speaks about having studied the jokes and humour, which were segmented, with people from Vidarbha preferring slapstick humour, while those in Konkan preferred wit.

"The BJP deployed its cultural knowledge of the area effectively in the Assembly poll in Maharashtra in 2014," she said.

Mhaskey is supposed to channel these segmented tier-two city and rural sensibilities in the BJP's communications game, but has had a rough start. Most of his team leaders, Priti Gandhi, Alok Bhatt and Arun Yadav, have had to delete objectionable posts from their social media handles, and some of the content put out by State BJP IT cells and even by the Centre trying to use Gen Z language has turned out to be tone-deaf.

When the new team was announced by the BJP, the party was careful to point out that six of the office-bearers were below the age of 40.

There are 15 between the ages of 40 and 49 and 21 between 50 and 59, bringing the average age of office-bearers to 50 years. More than 40% of the office-bearers come from marginalised communities. Moreover, 12 women from across the country have also made the cut.

The current national team faces the unprecedented challenge of steering the BJP's efforts to win a fourth term in office in 2029. Apart from the usual distribution of organisational berths to poll-going States, caste groups, and other demographics of gender and age, the new team reflects the BJP's attempts at a reset as the exigencies of three terms in power kick in.

nistula.hebbar@thehindu.co.in



BJP national president Nitin Nabin (seen folding his hands) receives a floral welcome upon his arrival to attend the party's State executive committee meeting, in Haldwani; he is joined by Uttarakhand Chief Minister Pushkar Singh Dhami (left). PTI

TELANGANA



The Greyhounds force was created by late IPS officer K.S. Vyas to take on Maoist insurgents on their own terrain. Within a few years, the striking unit evolved into one of the most specialised counter-insurgency units in the country, developing tactics suited to jungle warfare.

Created in 1989 to take on Maoists in the forests of undivided Andhra Pradesh, the Greyhounds became a specialised counter-insurgency force. Over three decades later, as the insurgency recedes, **Abhinay Deshpande** revisits the force's battles and its losses, the legacy of a war that shaped it, and how the Greyhounds are preparing for a future beyond the Maoist conflict

The bullet struck N.V. Satya Srinivas Rao in the chest. His bulletproof jacket stopped it, but the impact knocked his rifle from his hands and sent him to the ground.

Then came the second shot. This time, the bullet found a gap in the jacket. It entered Rao's abdomen from the left side, tore through his body and exited on the other side.

It was November 30, 1992. Rao, then 26 and barely a year into the Andhra Pradesh Police, had entered a house in Baddepalli in erstwhile Karimnagar district with three other Greyhounds personnel. They were hunting a group of Naxals belonging to the Chandra Pulla Reddy group. Five bodies already lay scattered around the house.

Rao noticed Sardar, the commander of the dalam. Injured but still alive, the Naxal had positioned himself behind the bodies of his fallen comrades, using them as sandbags. He raised his weapon and fired at Rao.

The young cop fought for his life for nearly 25 days before being discharged from the Nizam's Institute of Medical Sciences in Hyderabad on Christmas day.

"I was the first man to enter that house, and took a bullet. The training at Greyhounds made us fearless," he says. "The scars remind me of that day and how we fought the Naxals. It was a second birth for me."

The birth of a hunter

The Greyhounds was born out of a realisation that conventional policing was proving inadequate against the growing influence and armed strength of the Maoists. The then Andhra Pradesh government wanted a force that could take the fight into the forests and match the insurgents on their own terrain.

In 1989, IPS officer K.S. Vyas created the Greyhounds to combat the Maoist insurgency. Within a few years, the striking force had evolved into one of the country's most specialised counter-insurgency units, operating deep inside forests and developing tactics specifically suited to jungle warfare. It also became a model for other States seeking to create specialised units to fight insurgencies in difficult terrain. Odisha raised its Special Operations Group, Maharashtra its C-60, West Bengal its Counter-Insurgency Force and Chhattisgarh its District Reserve Guard. Even the CRPF's elite Commando Battalion for Resolute Action (CoBRA), drew from the Greyhounds' model.

"We are fearless. We never miss our target and have the highest success rate in the country," says DGP (Operations) Anil Kumar, who currently heads the Greyhounds.

This is Kumar's third stint with the elite force. He previously served as an ASP and later as a Group Commandant (Operations).

"In Andhra Pradesh and Telangana, I have fought against Naxals and faction groups. In Afghanistan, I was stationed in Kabul during the Taliban's march to power," he says.

When DIG Vyas took charge on June 15, 1989, the Greyhounds was a 350-member force, with nearly 90% of its personnel being constables. Vyas headed the unit until March 30, 1990. Over the years, its strength grew to over 2,000 at its peak. Today, following Union Home Minister Amit Shah's declaration in May that the country was Naxal-free, the force has 650 personnel, an officer says.

In the erstwhile Andhra Pradesh, the Greyhounds had 41 units, each comprising 35 person-

We are fearless. We never miss our target and have the highest success rate in the country... But we can proudly say that even though the outlawed force took shelter in tribal hamlets and used villagers as human shields, we never killed anyone by mistake.

ANIL KUMAR, DGP (Operations), Greyhounds



nel, including a DSP, an inspector and three sub-inspectors. There is no separate recruitment for the force. It is a deputation-based unit, with personnel volunteering from the Special Police, Armed Reserve and Civil Police.

Those seeking a posting with the Greyhounds are screened for physical fitness, mental resilience and the determination required for the job. Personnel deputed to the force receive 60% of their basic pay and dearness allowance for the duration of their posting.

Another officer associated with the unit since its inception said Vyas handpicked Narayan Singh Bhati, a former DIG of the erstwhile Special Security Bureau, now known as the Sashasthra Seema Bal, to build the Greyhounds' training programme.

Bhati, an authority on jungle warfare, designed its training modules and remained associated with the force as a consultant for nearly four decades. He was awarded the Padma Shri for his services and died in June 2023 at the age of 92.

"Our motto is 'strike first, strike hard,'" says Kumar even as he claims not a single innocent person has been killed by a Greyhounds bullet in the unit's history.

"We can proudly say that even though the outlawed force took shelter in tribal hamlets and used villagers as human shields, we never killed anyone by mistake. We identify the target first and strike only if required," he adds.

A person carrying a weapon and wearing an olive-green uniform was never, by itself, enough to be a target, the 1996-batch IPS officer asserts. "What if that person is a hunter or a village resident? We identify and confirm only when someone is carrying an SLR, AK or .303 rifle."

Naxals, he says, often move around in civilian clothes, making identification even more critical.

Recalling an operation at Manala in Nizamabad in March 2005, Kumar says the Greyhounds entered the area on a tip-off that a dalam was moving through the region. The operation came barely months after peace talks with the Maoists had broken down.

Despite an extensive search, the force could not locate the rebels. Then, an officer spotted a glint of metal on top of a hill. Suspecting it could be a steel plate, the team moved towards the spot, and his instinct proved right. Ten rebels were killed and a female cadre was arrested.

"She was later killed by Naxals after coming out on bail over suspicions that she was an informer," says Kumar, who was the Group Commandant (Operations) at the time.

For Kumar, the operation was a lesson in how seemingly small observations can determine the outcome of a mission: "It was the officers' keen observation that



helped the operation succeed. Every operation depends on efficiency, observation skills and leadership."

An attachment with the Greyhounds is mandatory for IPS officers undergoing training at the National Police Academy (NPA), while officers allotted to the Telugu States have a separate posting with the force.

Yet, in more than three decades, the Greyhounds has remained an almost exclusively male force. Not once has a woman headed it, nor has a single woman served in any of its operational units.

Cost of the war

The Greyhounds carried out numerous operations over the years, neutralising hundreds of rebels across Andhra Pradesh and Telangana. There were also instances when its teams crossed into neighbouring Maharashtra and Chhattisgarh to strike targets operating from across State borders.

But the striking force had another backbone: intelligence. At the heart of the Greyhounds' success was the Special Intelligence Branch (SIB), another specialised unit that emerged alongside the force to track the movement and activities of the rebels.

Since its inception, the Greyhounds has neutralised 693 rebels in undivided Andhra Pradesh and seized 1,250 firearms, Kumar says. Following the formation of Telangana on June 2, 2014, the force has killed 92 Naxals and recovered 360 weapons, he adds.

But the fight against the Red Army came at a heavy cost. The Greyhounds lost over 60 men over the years, including six after the formation of Telangana.

One of its biggest setbacks came on June 29, 2008, when Maoists ambushed a team on the Balimela reservoir in Odisha, killing 37 people, including 32 commandos.

The Greyhounds team had crossed into Odisha in pursuit of Maoists who had taken shelter there. Unable to locate them, the commandos were returning when Maoists, who had laid an ambush around the reservoir, opened fire on their boat. The attack sank the boat and became one of the darkest chapters in the force's history.

"Balimela was an opportunity ambush. We received information that Greyhounds personnel were crossing the river, mobilised quickly and launched the attack. It was a successful operation," says a former central committee (CC) member of CPI (Maoist). Barely four years after the force was formed, the man who designed it was killed by the enemy it was created to fight.

Vyas was jogging at Hyderabad's LB Stadium on January 27, 1993, when five members of the CPI (ML) People's War Group shot him dead in a surprise attack. He was among three IPS officers killed in A.P. by the rebels, along with G. Pardesi Naidu in November 1993 and C. Umesh Chandra in September 1999.

"At that time, Vyas was working actively and aggressively against the revolutionary movement, and so, the party decided to take action against him. By then, it was already known that the police had killed intellectuals and rights activists working in various fields in support of the movement in Telangana. It was as part of the Telangana party's decision, taken under such circumstances, to eliminate cruel officials," the former CC member says.

'Naxal-free' jungles

The decline of Maoist activity in Telangana had become so pronounced that B. Shivadhar Reddy, then DGP (Head of Police Force), declared the State "totally free of Maoist armed formations".

Shivadhar Reddy, now State Security Adviser, says that during his tenure as Additional Director General (Intelligence), DG (Intelligence) and later as DGP, from December 2023 to April 30 this year, as many as 817 rebels, including four CC members and 22 state committee members, surrendered while 138 were arrested. Police also seized 325 weapons, including 56 AK-47s.

He attributes the turnaround to a strategy of encouraging surrenders under a policy announced by Chief Minister A. Revanth Reddy. "It was a strategic decision, and due to the efforts of SIB, the party soon became headless, leaderless and rudderless."

Shivadhar Reddy says encounters or arrests could turn rebels into martyrs or heroes in the eyes of sections of society. "But surrender made them zeroes and demoralised their own cadre," he points out. With the Maoist threat receding, the Greyhounds and the SIB are preparing for a different challenge in the remote hills that once served as insurgent strongholds.

Reddy said intelligence inputs would be used to detect marijuana cultivation as roads and development reach those areas.

"We are building roads and development will follow. We do not want a situation like on the Andhra-Odisha Border (AOB), where marijuana cultivation is rampant and could, over the years, evolve into a violent crime syndicate. We will use the SIB's intelligence to identify such activity and then deploy the Greyhounds. They will ensure that there is no cultivation," he points out.

For Rao, however, the Greyhounds' history remains personal. Now Commandant of the Mamnoon Battalion and due for retirement next March, he still remembers Vyas visiting him at the hospital in January 1993, weeks after he was shot.

"Kya, Srinivas, darre kya (Were you scared, Srinivas)?" Vyas had asked him. "No, sir," Rao replied. Vyas responded, "Good. *Meeru anta puli pillalu, ayya* (You are all tiger cubs)!"

Two days later, Rao learnt that Vyas had been shot dead while jogging.

Business

INBRIEF



NSE’s ₹22,569-crore IPO fully subscribed on Day 2

The mega ₹22,569-crore initial public offering of the National Stock Exchange of India (NSE) was fully subscribed on the second day of bidding on Friday, driven by encouraging response from qualified institutional buyers and non-institutional investors. The NSE IPO received bids for 8,88,23,000 shares against 8,86,42,911 shares on offer, as per data available with the BSE till 2:56 PM. The category for Qualified Institutional Buyers (QIBs) was subscribed 1.32 times, while the non-institutional investors portion garnered 1.37 times subscription. The retail investors quota received 66 per cent subscription. The offering is India’s second-largest public issue after Hyundai Motor India’s ₹27,870-crore IPO in 2024.

‘MDR apprehension unlikely to spur higher cash usage’

Concerns that introducing a Merchant Discount Rate (MDR) would spur a surge in cash transactions are unlikely to materialise, RBI Deputy Governor Shirish Chandra Murmu said on Friday, adding that it was only an “initial apprehension”. “I don’t think that apprehension will come true,” he addressing a financial market conclave. “Because it is a major shift in terms of how basically you are recovering the cost. So, that’s why it may be apprehension only. I don’t think this will have any impact, unlike some voices about whether cash will go up because of this MDR.” On the apparent paradox of rising digital transactions and cash in circulation, Mr. Murmu said there was no paradox as cash serves both as a means of transaction and a store of value. “This cash paradox, actually, that is not my work. That is the way media has read it, and analysis has read it. Because it points towards data,” the Deputy Governor said.

Dr. Reddy’s to market Takeda’s dengue shot in India in H1-2027

The Hindu Bureau
HYDERABAD

Takeda’s dengue vaccine Qdenga is expected to be available in India in the first half of 2027. Dr Reddy’s Laboratories and Japan’s Takeda Pharmaceutical Company announced on Friday the signing of a distribution pact under which Dr Reddy’s will distribute the vaccine across India’s private market for pediatric and adult vaccination. “Subject to the completion of applicable processes with local authorities, the vaccine is anticipated to become available in the first half of 2027,” the companies stated. Qdenga is India’s first approved dengue vaccine.

In July, it got marketing authorisation from the Central Drugs Standard Control Organisation for those aged 4-60. Inclusion in India’s public immunisation programme remains an important long-term ambition.

Huge challenge Dengue is a significant public-health challenge in India with reported cases surging 11-fold over the past two decades. As per a study by the Virus Research and Diagnostic Laboratory of ICMR, all four dengue virus serotypes are co-circulating across multiple regions in India with one in 14 patients being infected with multiple dengue serotypes concurrently., the companies said

‘SP Group supports Tata Sons listing’

Welcoming the RBI’s decision to reject ‘Tata Sons’ application to surrender its registration and directing the company towards necessary compliance at the earliest, Shapoorji Pallonji Group Chairman says the regulator has provided full clarity

Lalendu Mishra
MUMBAI

Shapoorji Pallonji Group Chairman Shapoorji Pallonji Mistry said he ‘wholeheartedly’ welcomed the Reserve Bank of India’s decision with regard to Tata Sons and supported its listing “for the sake of transparency, accountability, fairness and responsible institution-building.” “The Reserve Bank of India has provided full clarity. Tata Sons had been classified as an upper layer NBFC under the RBI’s scale-based regulatory framework, and the prescribed listing route followed from that regulatory



architecture,” Mr. Mistry said in a statement. “With the RBI having rejected the application to surrender its registration and directing Tata Sons towards necessary compliance at the earliest, the path forward is clear,” the SP Group Chairman said. Stating that the ‘landmark’ decision should not be viewed as a victory of

The listing of Tata Sons can become a bridge... between shareholders and Trusts, between private heritage and public accountability

one stakeholder over another, he said it should be viewed as an opportunity to bring people and institutions together. “The listing of Tata Sons can become a bridge. A bridge between shareholders and Trusts, between private heritage and public accountability, between generations of stewardship, and between India’s

great past and the extraordinary future that lies ahead,” Mr. Mistry said. He said a transparent and publicly accountable Tata Sons could strengthen the entire ecosystem, broaden participation, enhance governance, give greater visibility to value, protect the legitimate interests of investors and provide the basis for a more robust and equitable dividend policy. “Most importantly, it can strengthen the capacity of the Tata Trusts to pursue their philanthropic responsibilities over generations,” he stated. “The millions of Indians who have invested in listed Tata companies are also part of this larger story.

They have placed their faith and their savings in the Tata name,” Mr. Mistry said. “A publicly accountable holding company can strengthen the relationship between that enormous community of investors and the institution whose success underpins the wider Tata ecosystem. Transparency, in my view, is the truest form of respect for both legacy and the future,” he pointed out. Calling upon every section of the Tata Group to come forward in a spirit of harmony and shared purpose, he said the listing should not be allowed to become even a minor point of division.

India Deep Tech Alliance invests ₹2,170 crore in 56 firms

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

The India Deep Tech Alliance (IDTA)’s members, which include individual and corporate investors from India and abroad, invested ₹2,170 crore in 56 deep-tech firms in India over the last year, the grouping announced at the Semicon India 2026 event. The investments were made “independently by individual IDTA members in accordance with their respective investment strategies and processes,” it said . Principal Scientific Adviser to the government Ajay Kumar Sood said the investments showed that the “vision” behind the ₹1 lakh crore Research, Development and Innovation (RDI) scheme of the Department of Science and Technology was “beginning to translate into measurable action”. “The RDI Scheme and industry-led initiatives can complement each other in strengthening the pathways through which promising technologies move from the laboratory to the market and create long-term strategic and economic value for India,” Mr. Sood said. Energy and climate-related start-ups got over 30% of the capital, with eight firms receiving ₹655 crore. Quantum, robotics and space start-ups received nearly a similar share, split among 21 companies. AI received nearly 30%, with 16 firms receiving ₹639 crore.

RBI may deliver two rate hikes by end of CY26, say analysts

The Hindu Bureau
MUMBAI

The Reserve Bank of India (RBI) is likely to raise the repo rate twice by as much as 50 basis points by the end of December 2026 in line with global tightening cycle and excess liquidity in the banking system. Analysts expect the Monetary Policy Committee (MPC) to deliver a 25 basis point rate hike in October 2026, followed by another 25 basis point increase in December, taking the benchmark repo rate to 5.75% by the end of the ca-



The MPC is expected to deliver a 25 bps rate hike in Oct. 2026.

lendar year. One basis point is equal to one-hundredth of a percentage point. The anticipated tightening comes amid concerns that inflation could exceed

the RBI’s earlier projections, particularly if crude oil prices remain elevated. “Incoming data suggests inflation is likely to overshoot those projections. If crude prices stay elevated in the \$90-\$110/barrel range, the pass-through from producer costs to final output prices is likely to accelerate,” Systematrix Group said in a report. “Against the prevailing 5.25% repo rate, it effectively implies a negative real policy rate – precisely the ‘cheap money’ condition we had warned was unsustainable,” it added.

FSSAI initiates legal action against Nestle

Press Trust of India
NEW DELHI

The Food Safety and Standards Authority of India (FSSAI) on Friday said it has initiated legal action against Nestle India Ltd. for alleged non-compliance with food safety norms in three infant nutrition products. According to FSSAI, it examined NAN Excella Pro Stage 1, Lactogen Pro 1, and a follow-up formula along with their promotional material available on e-commerce platforms. In NAN Excella Pro

Stage 1, the regulator flagged claims relating to “SHMOs” and “Whey Protein,” while in Lactogen Pro 1, it observed a claim describing “Whey Protein” as easy to digest. FSSAI sought clarifications from Nestle India. **Nestle’s response** Meanwhile, Nestle India said its infant nutrition products are “fully compliant” with all applicable regulations and that the labels of NAN Excella Pro and Lactogen Pro were approved by an expert committee of the FSSAI.

Peek into the future



Smooth drive: Tesla Cybercab car is displayed at a shopping mall in Shanghai. AFP

L&T eyes \$30 billion modularisation deals over five-year period

Lalendu Mishra
MUMBAI

Larsen & Toubro Ltd. (L&T) is positioning to capture a larger share of the global modular construction market, as rising labour costs and shortage of skilled workers push project developers towards factory-built modules for complex infrastructure and energy projects. The engineering and construction firm estimates the addressable global market for modularisation at about \$150 billion over the next five years, eyeing an almost \$20-30 billion share of the pie. “Modular concepts will be popular going forward,” said Subramanian Sarma, DMD and president, L&T,

adding the firm is also exploring greater adoption of modular construction in India while developing hybrid models combining modular and conventional construction to address transportation challenges. **Australian project** L&T’s focus on modularisation gained speed after the successful completion of fabrication and delivery of 110 modules weighing about 64,000 metric tonne for Project CERES, Australia’s largest urea making unit with 2.3 million tonne per annum capacity. The modules were fabricated at L&T’s modular fabrication facility near Chennai over 30 months and shipped to Australia through 23 voyages.

Higher advance tax mop-up boosts net direct tax collection by 13%

Press Trust of India
NEW DELHI

The government’s net direct tax collection rose 13% to more than ₹12.12 lakh crore till September 17 in the current financial year, buoyed by better advance tax mop-up from corporates, data released by CBDT on Friday showed. Advance tax mop-up grew 16.2% to about ₹5.22 lakh crore. This includes an 18% growth, at over ₹4.16 lakh crore, in advance tax payments by corporates, and a 9.24% rise in non-corporate advance tax of ₹1.06 lakh crore.



Gross direct tax collection clocked 15% growth.

Refunds jumped 29.2% to over ₹2.2 lakh crore till September 17 as per the Central Board of Direct Taxes (CBDT) data. Gross direct tax collec-

tion clocked 15% growth, totalling over ₹14.32 lakh crore. After adjusting for refunds, net collections from direct taxes (including corporate, non corporate, STT) grew 3% to over ₹12.12 lakh crore. The government has budgeted to collect Rs 26.97 lakh crore from direct taxes in the current financial year, a 15% growth over Rs 23.40 lakh crore collected in FY26. **Corporate tax mop-up** Net corporate tax mop-up rose 19.5% to about ₹5.56 lakh crore, while non-corporate tax (individuals and

HUFs) mop-up rose 6% to over ₹6.16 lakh crore. Securities Transactions Tax (STT) collection grew 53% to ₹40,214 crore between April 1 and September 17. Deloitte India partner, Rohinton Sidhwa said the over 50% rise in STT mop-up seems to be primarily driven by rate hikes in the Budget rather than a rise in turnover. A 150% hike was effected in STT rates on equity futures, effective April 1, 2026. AKM Global managing partner Amit Maheshwari, said the trends were broadly consistent with the underlying momentum in economy.

Private financing critical for Viksit Bharat goal: Economic Affairs Secy

Press Trust of India
NEW DELHI

Achieving India’s ‘Viksit Bharat’ vision will require critical private sector investment, as public expenditure alone cannot bridge the massive financing gap, Economic Affairs Secretary Anuradha Thakur said. Speaking at a conference of Finance Ministers and Finance Secretaries of States and Union Territories, Ms. Thakur highlighted the sovereign rating upgrades from major international rating agencies received by India over the past one-and-a-half



Anuradha Thakur

years, and said such global recognition underscores India’s growing economic strength, improving business climate, and strengthening position in the glo-

bal investment landscape. Stating that India holds “firm promise” to move forward on the already achieved goals and scale new heights, she said Centre-State partnership on policy issues, tapping financial sources and implementation can lead to Viksit Bharat decisively. “We know we meet today in the backdrop of ongoing global difficulties. Under the circumstances, and because of the scale of transformation we envisage ourselves to reach our shared goal, it needs to be borne in mind this scale cannot be met solely by go-

vernment budgets and private sector financing needs to play critical role.” The Secretary said the conference will keep this perspective at the forefront while discussing the theme ‘Financing India’s Journey Towards Viksit Bharat’. Noting the Centre-State partnership helped India get recognised by global agencies for macroeconomic stability and fiscal prudence, se said India is noted to be among the top attractive destinations for the global business environment, as highlighted in the WEF’s Chief Economists Outlook of May 2026.

Yemen conflict displaces 112,000 people inside country, says IOM



Pakistan court blocks expulsion of Afghan medical college students



Early voting begins in several U.S. States as part of midterm elections



Assad-era Syrian official jailed for 60 years by U.S. court for torture



Russia begins three days of voting in first wartime parliamentary poll

Associated Press
MOSCOW

Predetermined choice: An elderly man votes in parliamentary election at a polling station in St Petersburg in Russia on Friday. AFP

Thousands attend Iran's government-organised rally

Associated Press
CAIRO

A woman carries a rifle as she marches with other armed women and children during a military-style parade in Tehran on Friday. AP

Iran's Revolutionary Guards say they hit oil tanker in Hormuz

Agence France-Presse
TEHRAN

Show of support



China's ship 'rammed' vessel in South China Sea, says Philippines

Agence France-Presse
MANILA

Damaged railings on the port side of *BRP Datu Magat Salamat* after a collision. AFP

The Chinese vessel “rammed *BRP Datu Magat Salamat*... as it carried out its maritime patrol to deliver fuel subsidy to our fishermen”, Philippine Coast Guard spokesperson said.

Hundreds of civilians, prisoners suffer sexual abuse in Ukraine war, says UN

Agence France-Presse
GENEVA

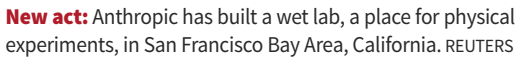
Ukrainians hold photos of their missing relatives as they watch freed Ukrainian soldiers arrive in the Chernihiv region of Ukraine. AP

U.K. says Falklands have 'right' to oil exploration after Argentine sanctions

Agence France-Presse
LONDON

Contested territory: The Falkland Islanders themselves voted overwhelmingly in 2013 to remain British. AFP

The Falkland Islanders themselves voted overwhelmingly in 2013 to remain British. But Argentina rejects that outcome, arguing that the principle of self-determination does not apply to a population it considers implanted by Britain after 1833.



Reuters
SAN FRANCISCO

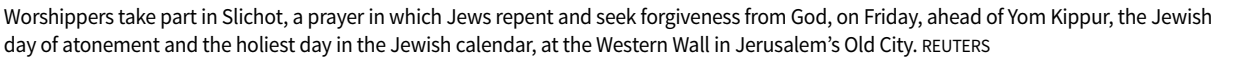
The Houthis captured

The Saudis and their allies have long struggled to contain or deter the Houthis, and may be tempted to seek a diplo-



The Houthis could still expand their target bank beyond Saudi ships and tankers. During their self-styled blockade of Israel at the height of the war in Gaza, the Houthis attacked

Regional mediators have sprung into action, but a diplomatic agreement appears unlikely without some kind of breakthrough in the wider Iran war. Iran wants the U.S. to lift a blockade and sanctions that have devastated its economy, while the U.S. seeks the full reopening of the Strait of Hormuz and a deal to roll back Tehran's nuclear programme. Neither side has shown any sign of biding since a pre-



As climate change accelerates, concerns mount over safety of these regions in the Himalayan belt. Flash floods last year in the same region too had caused extensive damage and claimed nine lives. Experts have called for stricter norms, assessing infrastructure for multiple disasters, focusing on development in less-dangerous areas and early warning systems.

Weekend Sport



GETTY IMAGES

Rags to riches – how Ollie Robinson plotted his way back from cricketing wilderness

The 32-year-old pacer spent more than two years outside the England Test set-up, with his fitness, pace and attitude all under a cloud. However, in a stunning turnaround, the swing and seam exponent has come charging back, helping England win four Tests this summer, and three of them with Player-of-the-Match performances.

Tarun Shastry

The official social media handle of the England and Wales Cricket Board recently crowned a ‘King’. Alongside videos celebrating his exploits, it declared – ‘New Ball King’.

Crowns, especially in England, are not handed out on a whim. They demand performances befitting royalty. This summer, one man has done just that, turning successive matches into his own royal procession – Ollie Robinson.

The road to royalty, however, has been anything but straightforward for the 32-year-old all-rounder. Before this summer, Robinson had last worn the England whites more than two years ago, against India in Ranchi in 2024, an outing where his returns were so meagre that he was banished from the English national cricketing scene.

Had it coming

The writing, though, had been on the wall for a while. Robinson’s fitness was a concern, dating back to the 2021-22 Ashes, before his back trouble resurfaced during the 2023 home season.

Then came Ranchi. A back spasm while batting was followed by 13 wicketless overs, with his pace at one stage dipping below 70mph. England



Just got the love of the game back, really. It’s only in the last few months that I’ve got the enjoyment back

OLLIE ROBINSON

had seen enough.

The then bowling coach Jon Lewis had made clear what Robinson needed to do. “If he’s going to perform consistently over a long period at this level, he’ll need to be a fitter bowler,” Lewis had said.

Robinson hardly helped his cause off the field either. During the same India tour, a podcast he hosted with his now spouse revealed behind-the-scenes details from the England camp, prompting the management to have the episode taken down.

While the England door remained firmly shut, Robinson went about rebuilding his career with Sussex. He helped the County earn promotion in 2024, and continued to pile up the wickets the following season.

Significantly, by the start of 2026, Sussex had entrusted him with something England never thought he could handle – the role of a leader.

Elevated to red-ball captaincy, Robinson embraced it. Sussex won three of its opening five County Championship matches, while the skipper led from the front with 17



wickets and 305 runs. There was even a back-to-the-wall, unbeaten century at No. 10 against Surrey at The Oval.

Rekindling the fun

The transformation, however, was not merely about wickets and runs. A winter spent playing grade cricket for Sydney University in Australia in late 2025 had helped Robinson rediscover his love for the game.

“Just got the love of the game back, really,” Robinson said during his comeback Test at Lord’s versus New Zealand this June. “It’s only, probably, in the last few months that I’ve got the enjoyment back. And knuckled down a bit more.”

It was a long way from where his mind had been a few months earlier. Around Christmas, Robinson had virtually resigned himself to the possibility of his England chapter being over. “I thought at Christmas time I was never playing for England again,” he admitted.

But he knew that if there was to be another chance, there was only one way of earning it. “As much as I obviously want to play for England again, I need to take wickets and rip up trees to receive that call,” he told *Wisden* before the season.

And rip he did, with the ball, the bat and as a leader.

The then red-ball head coach Brendon McCullum certainly took note. “We said bang the door down, and through the weight of performance in County cricket he has banged the door down,” gushed the Kiwi.

Striking gold

At Lord’s against New Zealand, Robinson needed all of six balls to remind England what it had been missing.

The first two deliveries of his return passed without incident. The third trapped Devon Conway in front. Two balls later, Kane Williamson



We said bang the door down, and through the weight of performance in County cricket, he has banged the door down

BRENDON MCCULLUM

lobbed one to short-leg for a duck before Rachin Ravindra was pinned down for a leg-before. A triple-wicket maiden – some way to announce a comeback!

Robinson was not done yet. To his five for 39 in the first innings, he added two wickets in the second, and chipped in with a valuable 29 with the bat as England completed a 115-run victory.

He missed the next two Kiwi Tests, the first owing to injury and the next because of non-selection. But the three Tests against Pakistan turned the comeback into a statement.

Robinson made the Dukes cherry swing, seam and dance both ways even as he used his height and high release-point to extract steep bounce.

There was the wobble-seam delivery that would hold its line, the nip-backer that would dart in, and the full inswinger. Pakistan was left bamboozled.

England added another little twist to the plan – Jamie Smith standing up to the stumps to stop Pakistan batters from venturing on adventures down the pitch, allowing the seamer to keep at-tacking the stumps.

It began at Headingley with the very first ball of the series as Robinson trapped Azan Awa in front. His five for 51 was followed by three for 29 as England romped home by an innings and 103 runs.

Relentless

Lord’s brought no respite for Pakistan. Robinson’s first five-over spell cost just six runs before he returned for another seven overs that went for only four and fetched four wickets. Four for 11 in the first innings; another four in the second; England had the series in the bag. Three Tests into his return. Three Player-of-the-Match awards.

Edgbaston merely extended Pakistan’s torment. Robinson’s three for 15 in the first essay included his 100th Test wicket before he swapped ball for bat and cracked a 47-ball 50. Then, back with ball in hand, he removed Saim Ayub first delivery and Abdullah Shafique three balls later.

Pakistan eventually found a way to blunt him, but it was a little too late as England completed an eight-wicket victory and a 3-0 sweep. Robinson had 21 wickets from the three fixtures at a mind-boggling average of 8.76 and an economy rate of 2.04.

Numbers, though, told only half the story.

The 32-year-old’s skill was never under question. It was whether his body and mind could sustain the rigours of the highest level. McCullum had put it rather plainly: “When his pace drops to 75, 76mph and the threat diminishes, he is not the same bowler.”

There, perhaps, was the difference.

The Robinson who laboured through Ranchi at under 70mph had returned fitter, happier and clearer in the mind. The height and movement were the same. The control was still there. But now, he had the body to keep it all going. The result was 28 wickets from four Tests and England’s Test Player-of-the-Summer award.

There will be tougher examinations. The Dukes will refuse to dance to his tune sometimes; conditions will not always favour him; better batting line-ups will find ways to get runs off him.

But for a man who spent more than two years out in the cold, Robinson has certainly turned up the heat this summer. Nine months since that contemplative Christmas, he is the No. 3 bowler in the world.

“The hard work’s not done yet. We’re just getting started,” said Robinson. More coronations in store? Time will tell.

STACKING UP



English Premier League Standings										
#	Team	GP	W	D	L	GF	GA	GD	PTS	
1	Arsenal	4	4	0	0	8	1	7	12	
2	Manchester City	4	4	0	0	8	2	6	12	
3	Leeds United	4	2	2	0	7	3	4	8	
4	Hull City	4	2	2	0	5	2	3	8	
5	Brighton	4	2	1	1	13	5	8	7	
6	Chelsea	4	2	1	1	10	9	1	7	
7	Brentford	4	1	3	0	7	4	3	6	
8	Liverpool	4	1	3	0	6	4	2	6	
9	Everton	4	1	3	0	5	3	2	6	
10	Ipswich Town	4	2	0	2	7	10	-3	6	
11	Nottingham Forest	4	1	2	1	4	4	0	5	
12	Newcastle United	4	1	2	1	7	8	-1	5	
13	Manchester United	4	1	1	2	7	7	0	4	
14	Sunderland	4	1	1	2	3	5	-2	4	
15	Bournemouth	4	0	3	1	6	7	-1	3	
16	Crystal Palace	4	1	0	3	6	11	-5	3	
17	Tottenham Hotspur	4	0	2	2	0	5	-5	2	
18	Fulham	4	0	1	3	4	7	-3	1	
19	Aston Villa	4	0	1	3	1	7	-6	1	
20	Coventry City	4	0	0	4	0	10	-10	0	

Italian Serie A Standings										
#	Team	GP	W	D	L	GF	GA	GD	PTS	
1	Roma	4	4	0	0	12	1	11	12	
2	Inter	4	4	0	0	13	6	7	12	
3	Como	4	3	1	0	9	4	5	10	
4	Lazio	4	3	1	0	6	3	3	10	
5	Cagliari	4	3	0	1	4	2	2	9	
6	Milan	4	2	2	0	7	4	3	8	
7	Frosinone	4	2	1	1	7	4	3	7	
8	Juventus	4	2	1	1	6	4	2	7	
9	Sassuolo	4	2	1	1	8	7	1	7	
10	Napoli	4	2	0	2	6	5	1	6	
11	Atalanta	4	2	0	2	5	5	0	6	
12	Lecce	4	2	0	2	5	7	-2	6	
13	Udinese	4	1	1	2	8	10	-2	4	
14	Torino	4	1	0	3	4	7	-3	3	
15	Florentina	4	1	0	3	5	11	-6	3	
16	Bologna	4	0	1	3	2	5	-3	1	
17	Parma	4	0	1	3	2	6	-4	1	
18	Monza	4	0	1	3	6	11	-5	1	
19	Genoa	4	0	1	3	2	8	-6	1	
20	Venezia	4	0	0	4	4	11	-7	0	

Spanish LaLiga Standings										
#	Team	GP	W	D	L	GF	GA	GD	PTS	
1	FC Barcelona	6	6	0	0	28	6	22	18	
2	Real Madrid	6	5	0	1	17	6	11	15	
3	Real Betis	6	5	0	1	8	6	2	15	
4	Atlético	6	4	1	1	14	6	8	13	
5	Sevilla	6	4	1	1	9	6	3	13	
6	Alavés	6	3	1	2	11	6	5	10	
7	RC Deportivo	6	2	3	1	9	7	2	9	
8	RCD Espanyol	6	2	1	3	9	7	2	7	
9	Athletic Club	5	2	1	2	7	6	1	7	
10	R. Racing Club	6	2	1	3	11	16	-5	7	
11	Rayo Vallecano	6	2	1	3	10	15	-5	7	
12	Real Sociedad	6	2	1	3	6	11	-5	7	
13	Osasuna	6	2	1	3	5	12	-7	7	
14	Villarreal	6	1	2	3	10	11	-1	5	
15	Levante	5	1	2	2	7	9	-2	5	
16	Getafe	6	1	2	3	3	7	-4	5	
17	Celta	6	0	4	2	3	6	-3	4	
18	Valencia	6	1	1	4	2	10	-8	4	
19	Málaga	6	0	3	3	3	11	-8	3	
20	Elche	6	0	2	4	8	16	-8	2	

German Bundesliga Standings										
#	Team	GP	W	D	L	GF	GA	GD	PTS	
1	Freiburg	3	3	0	0	10	1	9	9	
2	Dortmund	3	3	0	0	8	2	6	9	
3	Augsburg	3	2	1	0	9	3	6	7	
4	Bayern Munich	3	2	1	0	7	2	5	7	
5	RB Leipzig	3	2	0	1	9	3	6	6	
6	Elversberg	3	2	0	1	8	7	1	6	
7	Leverkusen	3	1	1	1	8	5	3	4	
8	Mainz	3	1	1	1	6	3	3	4	
9	Frankfurt	3	1	1	1	7	8	-1	4	
10	Werder Bremen	3	1	1	1	5	6	-1	4	
11	Schalke	3	1	1	1	3	3	0	4	
12	Cologne	3	1	1	1	5	7	-2	4	
13	Hoffenheim	3	1	0	2	6	7	-1	3	
14	VfB Stuttgart	3	1	0	2	6	8	-2	3	
15	Paderborn	3	0	1	2	4	4	-1	1	
16	Union Berlin	3	0	1	2	4	10	-6	1	
17	Mönchengladbach	3	0	0	3	3	12	-9	0	
18	Hamburg	3	0	0	3	0	12	-12	0	



ATP Men's Top 15				
#	Player	Age	Points	Events
1	Jannik Sinner	25	11,500	17
2	Alexander Zverev	29	9,690	20
3	Carlos Alcaraz	23	5,560	17
4	Ben Shelton	23	4,680	22
5	Félix Auger-Aliassime	26	3,890	22
6	Daniil Medvedev	30	3,770	24
7	Flavia Cobolli	24	3,720	26
8	Frances Tiafoe	28	3,380	22
9	Alex de Minaur	27	3,300	24
10	Taylor Fritz	28	3,175	22
11	Arthur Fils	22	3,150	18
12	Novak Djokovic	39	2,980	16
13	Learner Tien	20	2,755	22
14	Rafael Jódar	19	2,659	22
15	Jakub Menšík	21	2,495	21

Top Indians ▶

Sumit Nagal Rank 247 ▼ 11 spots	Dhakshinewar Suresh Rank 367 ▲ 1 spot

WTA Women's Top 15				
#	Player	Age	Points	Events
1	Elena Rybakina	27	9,901	21
2	Aryna Sabalenka	28	7,875	18
3	Jessica Pegula	32	7,265	19
4	Coco Gauff	22	7,244	18
5	Mirra Andreeva	19	5,743	20
6	Linda Noskova	21	5,328	20
7	Elina Svitolina	32	4,809	17
8	Karolina Muchova	30	4,683	20
9	Iga Swiatek	25	4,619	19
10	Marta Kostyuk	24	3,980	16
11	Amanda Anisimova	25	3,363	15
12	Sahibzada Farhan	862	848	
13	Belinda Bencic	29	2,935	18
14	Diana Shnaider	22	2,588	24
14	Victoria Mboko	20	2,521	19
15	Sorana Cirstea	36	2,464	23

Top Indians ▶

Sahaja Yamalapalli Rank 349 ▼ 8 spots	Vaishnavi Adkar Rank 363 ▲ 29 spots

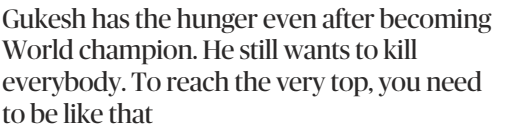


Test Batting			
#	Player	Rating	Career best
1	Harry Brook	861	898
2	Steve Smith	840	947
3	Joe Root	816	932
4	Travis Head	811	884
5	Temba Bavuma	775	806
6	Rachin Ravindra	740	740
7	Rishabh Pant	713	801
8	Daryl Mitchell	710	804
9	Shubman Gill	709	807
10	Kamindu Mendis	706	784

ODI Batting			
#	Player	Rating	Career best
1	Shubman Gill	801	841
2	Daryl Mitchell	794	840
3	Virat Kohli	767	908
4	Rohit Sharma	758	879
5	Ibrahim Zadran	719	756
6	Babar Azam	689	894
7	Joe Root	674	810
8	Shai Hope	673	782
9	Charith Asalanka	659	705
10	Harry Tector	653	730

T20I Batting			
#	Player	Rating	Career best
1	Ishan Kishan	913	916
2	Abhishek Sharma	862	931

A photograph showing two men sitting at a table, focused on a chess game. The man on the left is wearing a dark suit and has his hand on his chin, looking intently at the board. The man on the right is wearing a grey shirt and is also looking down at the chess pieces. The chessboard is set up with various colored pieces (yellow, red, black) on a dark surface. In the background, there are blurred figures of people and a blue wall.



pens sometimes. I am sure he will be back to his best. Pragg has had a phenomenal run of late, and he is mentally strong, like we saw recently in the Grand Chess Tour final against Fabiano Caruana. He was down by six points at one stage, but came back and won the match. Nihal is very tricky and does well in time scrambles. I have played with him a lot online and he is very, very strong in bullet chess.

You beat Gukesh at the Grand Swiss last year and became the youngest player to beat a defending World champion...

That was a very interesting game. Before the start, I realised I had two options. I was white, yes, so I could play something solid and I could try to press a little bit. But he is very strong, so it was unlikely I would be able to create real chances and win unless he made some very big mistakes.

The other choice was that I could view this game as a unique opportunity to create history. If I had lost that game, no one would have remembered, but it was an opportunity to beat the World champion.

That's something I wanted to. So I decided to play the sharpest line in my repertoire (Bg5 in the Italian Game) but he has one of the world's greatest opening preparations. He had come prepared for this, and I was thinking over the board, and I had this idea to sacrifice a piece. You are playing against the World champion, so sacrificing a piece is probably the last thing to do.

But I was trying to replicate what Arjun does in these scenarios. I mean, it was fine as long as I understood what I was doing in this position. During the Grand Swiss, I felt like I was sort of untouchable. I was in a very good state of mind, and it was like I would play my best chess.

If Gukesh wanted, he could have made a draw. But he desperately wanted to win. He has this hunger even after becoming World champion... he still wants to kill everybody. This is both a positive and negative trait, but I believe if you want to reach the very top, you need to be like this. You will lose games, but you will win more.

In our game, he tried to do this, but it backfired, and I found some very accurate moves. I got to a rook ending, and then clearly converted my advantage.

There doesn't seem to be as much support for chess in the United States as in a country like India...

Yes, it is quite difficult to be a full-time chess player in the USA. I don't really have sponsors, but I am a very positive person. I hope things can still work. And yes, the Kasparov Chess Foundation has been supporting me.

In his maiden Global Chess League foray, American chess prodigy Abhimanyu Mishra was part of a side that finished sixth out of six. But the 17-year-old Grandmaster thinks highly of the star-studded, innovative competition. He talks about playing in India, his chess journey, and the strengths of reigning World champion Gukesh among others



Abhimanyu Mishra

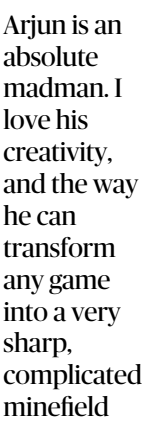
P.K. Ajith Kumar

Abhimanyu Mishra became the world's youngest Grandmaster at the age of 12 in 2021. He still has that record. He is also the youngest player to defeat a reigning World champion. Excerpts from an interview Abhimanyu gave *The Hindu* in Bengaluru, where he played for PBG Alaskan Knights in the Tech Mahindra Global Chess League:

How do you look back at your journey of becoming the youngest Grandmaster?

It was part of a bucket list. It was in the middle of the pandemic. Everything in the world had shut down, and I desperately wanted to break this record. I went eight months without playing any tournament. Me and my dad decided to take this insurmountable risk. I am not sure if I would take the same risk today. We went to a different country in the middle of a global pandemic, and if either of us got the virus, we would be admitted to a hospital. It would have been an absolute nightmare.

But despite all odds, we decided to take the risk. Taking the risk was one thing, but getting the title was another. I had a rating of about



2410 and no Grandmaster norms (a player needs three). I think I scored norms from two of the first three events, and after that I hit a dry streak. I had to hit the rating of 2500 for the Grandmaster title. I was missing the final norm narrowly. But I made it in cinematic style in the last tournament. I needed to win with black pieces against [India's] Leon Mendonca, and I did. I was euphoric that this journey was finally over for me and my family.

You had another interesting game with Mendonca here at the GCL. From a winning position, you put your promoted queen on the wrong square, and he claimed it was an illegal move. The arbiter agreed, and you had to replay the move in one second, which was humanly impossible. And you lost on time...

We would have needed an F1 driver to make a move so fast. But I am okay with the claim made by Leon. It is what you do, especially in a team event, where every point matters. I would have done the same. I would do a lot worse actually.

**Your thoughts
on your maiden
GCL?**

I actually wanted
to play last year,
but it did not work

out. I had some school obligations and some other stuff, so unfortunately I couldn't play. I was determined to play this year. I had been following the GCL from the beginning and I found it entertaining. This is a very strong event. We have the world's best players. From the spectators' point of view too, it is an exciting event. It is good to see the audience cheering for you from inside the venue. It actually gives chess a new life in some regard.

I loved being part of my GCL team, PBG Alaskan Knights. We had [Viswanathan] Anand, who is one of the greatest players of all time. There was Arjun Erigaisi, who is very creative and an absolute madman. I love his creativity, and the way he can transform any game into a very sharp, complicated minefield. Arjun also has the ability to take risks, and that is very important. He doesn't mind being in a minus position, according to the computer, but as long as he is comfortable, he would go for anything. We also had in our team Yagiz Kaan Erdogmus, who is very, very strong.

Your thoughts on the other prodigies of Indian chess - Gukesh, Praggnanandhaa and Nihal Sarin?

Gukesh has this ability to bounce back from very tough situations. Yes, his recent form hasn't been good, but it hap-

The Incredible Trio

There was a time when Kevin Young's men's 400m hurdles world record of 46.78s, created at the 1992 Barcelona Olympics, seemed set to stay for eternity. That was until Karsten Warholm bettered the mark in July 2021 (46.70s) before achieving the impossible at the Tokyo Olympics by going under 46 seconds. But little did the Norwegian expect Brazilian Alison Dos Santos to not only break his record but register another sub-46 timing, with both efforts coming in a fortnight's span between August 27 and September 13, in Zurich and Budapest, respectively. Rivaling these two is American Raj Benjamin, who took gold in Paris 2024 and the silver behind Warholm in Tokyo. The dominant trio has swept the podiums at Tokyo and Paris, and accounted for the top-37 times in the discipline's history. Young is now a distant 38th. That's progression for you!

Athlete	Time	Date
Alison Dos Santos	45.80s	27 Aug, 2026
Karsten Warholm	45.94	3 Aug, 2021
Alison Dos Santos	45.98	13 Sep, 2026
Rai Benjamin	46.17	3 Aug, 2021
Karsten Warholm	46.28	16 Aug, 2025
Alison Dos Santos	46.29	19 Jul, 2022
Rai Benjamin	46.39	16 Sep, 2023
Rai Benjamin	46.40	13 Sep, 2026
Alison Dos Santos	46.43	23 Aug, 2026
Rai Benjamin	46.46	30 Jun, 2024
Rai Benjamin	46.46	9 Aug, 2024



Raking in the moolah

The United States is famously called the land of opportunity. This is perhaps why FIFA took the World Cup to North America this summer. This is also perhaps why World Rugby will take

its men's World Cup to the U.S. in 2031 and the women's competition in 2033.

Last Saturday in Baltimore, Maryland, was a precursor, wherein a record 68,173 fans watched two-time defending World champion Springboks (South Africa) defeat three-time winner All Blacks (New Zealand) in the fourth and final Test of

Rugby's Greatest Rivalry Series.

The first three Tests were held in South Africa, and it was the first time in three decades that the All Blacks had embarked on a tour of the Rainbow Nation. That such a historic series had its last stop in the U.S. says a lot. *ESPN* revealed that the two countries would each earn \$9 million more in

the U.S. than in South Africa.

The U.S. has historically been cold to rugby, and the World Cup will mostly be attractive to the diaspora and the travelling fans.

No wonder only around 10% of the tickets in Baltimore were sold to those from the area. And 'tourists over locals' is an economic axiom.